



ARGENTINA

Capital city: Buenos Aires
Area: 1,068,296 sq miles (2,766,890 sq km)
Population: 38,400,000
Official language: Spanish
Major religions: Christian 92%, Jewish 2%, other 6%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Argentine peso
Adult literacy rate: 97%
Life expectancy: 74 years
People per doctor: 370
Televisions: 289 per 1,000 people

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STRETCHING FROM THE SUBTROPICAL forests of the north, down across the vast central plains of the Pampas, to the snowcapped mountains of Patagonia in the south, Argentina occupies most of southern South America. The country is bounded by the Andes Mountains in the west, and slopes gently downhill to the Atlantic Ocean in the east. Today's population is a mixture of native Indians, Spanish settlers, and immigrants from southern Europe who arrived during the past 100 years. The country is relatively wealthy, but has suffered from years of political instability, with periods of military rule alternating with elected governments.



BUENOS AIRES

Almost 40 percent of Argentinians live in or near the capital city of Buenos Aires, making it one of the major cities in the southern half of the world. The city was founded by the Spanish in 1536 as a port on the Río de la Plata, and inhabitants are still called *porteños*, meaning "people of the port." Modern Buenos Aires is highly sophisticated, with grand avenues, a subway system, and expensive stores. It is the trading center of the country, and most of Argentina's exports are shipped through its docks.



MEDIA AND NEWSPAPERS

Argentinians can choose from a range of about 180 daily newspapers, among them *El Crónista*, *La Nación*, and *Clarín*, which has the biggest circulation of any newspaper in South America. Most are published in Spanish, but German, English, and French language papers circulate widely. The constitution of Argentina guarantees freedom of the press, but during some military dictatorships, newspapers and television have been heavily censored.

FALKLAND ISLANDS

Some 300 miles (480 km) east of Argentina lie the disputed Islas Malvinas. Occupied by Spain in 1767, the islands were invaded by Britain in 1833 and renamed the Falkland Islands. Britain and Argentina have contested ownership ever since. In 1982 an Argentinian invasion was repelled by Britain, which now has a military garrison there.



Simple potato pasta is traditionally eaten at the end of the month, just before payday.



ITALIAN IMMIGRANTS

In the years leading up to World War I in 1914, about 2 million people fled the poverty of southern Europe to start a new life in Argentina. More than half came from Italy, finding work on the land or in the expanding cities of Buenos Aires and Rosario. Italian food, such as the potato pasta *noquis*, is still served in restaurants throughout Argentina.

TIERRA DEL FUEGO

When Ferdinand Magellan and his Spanish crew first saw the rocky islands at the tip of Argentina in 1520, they named them Tierra del Fuego, or Land of Fire, because they saw fires lit by the Fuegian Indians to keep warm. The islands, shared between Argentina and Chile, are wet and windswept, with glaciers carving out huge valleys in the mountains.



DANCING THE TANGO

Tango, the national music of Argentina, began in the slums of Buenos Aires. The music, and the dramatic dance style that goes with it, reflects the hopes of working people and is sometimes happy, but often sad. Tango music is played on a *bandoneon*, a type of accordion, with a piano and violin accompaniment.